EULOGY FOR BRIAN

From his brother James

I am Brian's brother Jimmy.

At Archbishop Ryan, I remember Brian flipping between the number one and number two ranked student of a large class — all while being All-Catholic in four sports: soccer, indoor track, outdoor track, and cross country. And he won the physics award.

Even so, it was a surprise when the letters started coming in from Harvard, recruiting Brian — because Archbishop Ryan had never received a letter from Harvard. Then the other Ivy League schools started reaching out.

His childhood friend Tim Roach was already at Bucknell, and Brian Roach was about to join him. The two Brians were the same age, and we all hung out so much we used full names just to tell everyone apart: Brian Breslin and Brian Roach, Jim Breslin and Jim Roach. People would hear that and be puzzled — like we were some weird tribe that used full names. Then, in addition, Jamie Silva — one of Brian's relay race partners at Ryan — committed to Bucknell.

Brian Breslin went to Bucknell.

He majored in physics and mathematics. And then after, he went to work at Lockheed Martin — for a bit. Then layoffs came — last in, first out — and Brian and another new guy were of course in the mix. Brian told my dad he was going to step aside. The other guy had a family. And that's what he did — no fanfare. He quietly did the right thing.

After college, Brian's coaches from Parkwood and Ryan had connections to the only pro team in the region — the Philadelphia KiXX. They told Brian he was good enough to play there, and they got him into the tryouts. Brian played well at forward, his position. Then, with most of the players cut and Brian in the final group to make the team, one of the defenders got injured. The coaches asked if someone could volunteer to play

defense. Brian had never played defense. None of the players raised their hand, for fear of looking bad. So Brian did. He played well — but of course, from defense, he didn't look like the same dangerous player he is. Brian didn't make the final cut. But again — he volunteered for something difficult, and sacrificed.

And Brian was a teacher outside the classroom too. His good friend Marcelo has a son, Jonathan. Brian tutored Jonathan in mathematics from the time he was little — year after year. Jonathan is an engineer now. He builds pacemakers. Think about that. Brian spent years putting mathematics into a kid, and that kid grew up to build the machines that keep hearts beating.

Brian's room was filled with books on physics — not to show off; that was never his nature. He studied how the physical world worked, and he was very good at it. But in the end, he always chose the most important thing in this physical world. People.

Now — Brian was my best man at my wedding. He got up and said he had prepared just a few Jimmy stories. I should explain what he meant by a Jimmy story. In physics, there is a law that for every action there is an equal and opposite reaction. And I grew up with Brian. So for every exceptionally smart thing Brian did, I did an equally exceptionally stupid thing. He said he had just a few — but he was carrying a big fishbowl filled to the top with hundreds of slips of paper. And he started pulling them out, one at a time, roasting me with a story each time — and everyone laughing at my expense, of course. Well… not everyone. My poor mother-in-law — a cop in the 25th District — the Kensington Badlands — was having a panic attack thinking Brian was actually going to read them all. She was waving at him to stop — thinking he had surely lost his mind — doing everything to get his attention short of pulling her night stick on him, while the rest of the room clamoured for more. As usual, Brian tried to do something difficult — jokes, stories, pranks — all with love and no meanness, all rolled into one best man's speech. And it all landed.

Now — religion and physics. In addition to his background in physics and mathematics, Brian was a Catholic school student for twelve years, and a Catholic school teacher as well. The reflexive instinct is that those two things don't mix — that you have to pick one. But some of the best minds in human history looked hard at both, and realized they are the same.

We all know, from our Saint Anselm and Archbishop Ryan upbringing, that our religion teaches that we are eternal beings. That this life is not the end. That we simply change form — and continue to live in that new form. Scripture even says it in a runner's language: the people who go before us don't leave us — they surround us, a great cloud of witnesses, while we run our own race. Brian finished his race. Now he is in the cloud, watching us run ours. The funeral Mass says it in five words: *life is changed, not ended*.

Physics says the same thing, in its most famous law: the conservation of mass. For the public school kids, the conservation of mass states that matter cannot be created or destroyed. It only changes form. Burn a log and the wood is not gone — it becomes heat and light and smoke and ash, and if you could weigh every bit of it, you would get the log back to the gram. Even the Big Bang was proposed by a Catholic priest — Father Georges Lemaître, a physicist in a Roman collar. Nothing is ever destroyed. It is only rearranged.

Albert Einstein said it straight out: *"Science without religion is lame. Religion without science is blind."* One cannot walk without the other. One cannot see.

I have a lot more of these. And I thought about bringing a fishbowl of my own today — filled to the top with quotes, just to scare everyone into thinking I was going to read every one of them. But I didn't think I could bring a fishbowl of crinkled paper into church. So — one more.

Brian's favorite comedian was Norm Macdonald. And you might assume a comedian like Norm didn't believe in any of this. You'd be wrong. Norm said: *"Smart man says*

nothing is a miracle. I say everything is."

We had a breakdancing crew in Parkwood with some other kids in the neighborhood, like members of the Heron and Jackson families — and Brian was our ace. He could do airborne windmills, which is of course the most difficult breakdance move there is. When we went to Chuck E. Cheese and had break-offs with other neighborhoods, the other kids would come up afterward and offer to pay Brian to teach them. He taught them. He didn't take the money. One time we entered a city-sponsored dance competition. And like in track, Brian was our anchor leg — he went last, after everyone else had gone. In the local stage it was all breakdance crews. But as we advanced through the city, it was ballet dancers and classically trained acts — and we were the only breakdance crew left. But when Brian would tell the city breakdance story, it was never about the winning, or the devastating airborne windmill. It was about the absurdity and hilarity of the announcer — who introduced all the classically trained acts, and then had to say, every time: and now… the *Fresh Express*. For Brian, that was worth all the bruises learning the moves.

The other night we watched a video my niece Ava filmed years ago: Brian, my nephew Michael, my sister Terryan, my mother, my son Luke, and my daughter Grace — who was about four at the time — playing duck duck goose. Every time Grace got tagged she ran the wrong way, and when that didn't work, she started working the refs. And there was Brian, patient as ever, guiding her around the circle, soothing the frustrations, keeping the game going. Until at some point he said, out loud: maybe duck duck goose is for ages five and up.